Brown

Support · rootedness · home

You meet brown at breakfast, on tree bark, in a mug of coffee or in your favourite shoes. You usually notice it only when it is missing. It can be warm, soft and sensual, at other times heavy and settled. It depends not only on the shade but also on what stands next to it and how you feel in it at that moment.

This page does not tell you what brown means. **It shows it to you from several sides**. How it is mixed, how it is painted with, where its reputation comes from, how it is read in different cultures and **what it can awaken in us**.

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How to mix the colour and its shades

Brown is not one colour that you discover every time you fail to rinse your brush for long enough. It arises in several ways and each turns out a little differently. The more mixtures you try, the better you will see what you are looking for in it.

Ready-made brown tubes have their charm, but **mixing teaches you the most**. You will see how yellow, red and blue pull against each other, and when a warm earthy colour turns to mud. Start small, on paper, and write down what produced what.

What to prepare



Yellow
The base of warm brown and ochre shades.



Red
Gives a rusty or chestnut tinge.



Blue
In tiny doses it mutes and cools.



White
For beige, sandy and coffee shades.



Yellow ochre
A ready-made earth pigment that turns brown honey-like.



Sienna
Yellow-brown natural or red-brown burnt.



Umber
A muted brown, the burnt one is darker and warmer.

What sienna and umber mean

Raw sienna tends to be yellow-brown, burnt sienna a more distinct red-brown. Raw umber tends to be a muted brown, sometimes with a greenish tinge, burnt umber is darker and warmer. **The exact look differs between manufacturers.**

The names may sound like a guest list for a foreign tour, but on the palette they are very practical. You can also get brown by muting red with green or yellow with purple. The same shade will not always result.

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What the additions do



Yellow

Shifts toward warm, honey and golden. Add little by little.





Red

Shifts toward chestnut and rust. Watch for an over-brick look.





Blue

Cools and mutes. Add by the drop, it can take over the whole mixture.





White

Lightens to beige and sand. Too much white makes it a dull grey-brown.





Black

Shifts toward chocolate and almost black. Use only the tip.





Green

Mutes red undertones and adds a forest tinge.



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Ten browns to try

A part can be a drop or an equally large dab of paint. **Treat the proportions as a starting point** for experimenting, not as a guarantee of the same shade with every brand.

Basic warm brown



2 parts yellow and 1 part red, then gradually a small amount of blue. Warm and earthy.

Rust



An orange base and a little blue. Let the warm shade keep the upper hand.

Chestnut



Brown and a small amount of red. Glossy and deep.

Dark chocolate



Burnt umber and a trace of blue, adjust the red according to the result.

Honey brown



Yellow ochre and gradually added warm brown. Light and warming.

Sand



A lot of white, ochre and a trace of brown. Dry and calm.

Beige



White and a small amount of brown, for a warmer tone a trace of ochre. Soft and unobtrusive.

Coffee with milk



Gradually add brown into white. Friendly and homely.

Cool grey-brown



Brown and a tiny bit of blue, adjust the lightness with white. Quiet and urban.

Pink-brown



White, brown and a tiny addition of red or magenta. Soft and a little powdery.

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Rainbow – the chakra system

Brown has **no stripe of its own** in the rainbow. Yet without it you can hardly imagine a landscape, trunks, soil, branches, seeds and stones. In the current seven-colour chakra map some modern approaches place it next to red, with the **root chakra** and the themes of **grounding** and home base.

The whole rainbow as a map of questions

Red · root
Support, safety, presence. Ask yourself. What can I lean on?

Orange · sacral
Experiencing, pleasure, sensuality. Ask yourself. What does me good?

Yellow · solar plexus
Self-worth, will, decision-making. Ask yourself. What do I want to choose for myself?

Green · heart
Closeness, kindness, relationships. Ask yourself. Where can I be open and still stay with myself?

Blue · throat
Voice, expression, communication. Ask yourself. What do I need to say?

Indigo · third eye
Inner vision, intuition, discernment. Ask yourself. What is beginning to dawn on me?

Violet · crown
Transcendence, meaning, connection. Ask yourself. What gives me a wider sense of meaning?

Brown · beside the root
Home base and nourishment. Ask yourself. What really supports me in everyday life?

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Muladhara, the root chakra

Chakras come from the Indian yogic and tantric tradition. The first chakra is called Muladhara. It sits at the base of the spine and, according to descriptions, has four petals. In classical texts red is linked with it. Brown is added to it only in some contemporary approaches, as an accompaniment to earth, physicality and grounding.

Its theme is **support**, safety and the feeling that you have your place in the world. It need not be anything grand. It is an ordinary table, regular meals, a safe home or a person in front of whom you do not have to perform. Roots are mostly unseen too, and yet a tree relies on them a great deal.

When the chakra is in balance. You have something to lean on and you do not have to be always ready to bolt. You can rest and yet are not afraid to move.

When the chakra is out of balance. Modern interpretations describe either insecurity and constant vigilance, or on the contrary too much clinging to certainties. These are not proofs of the state of a chakra, they are situations in which you can get to know yourself. **A habit that protects you does not have to prevent your next step.**

In today's approach brown is one of the companions of this chakra beside red. It serves you as a reminder and a support. It is not a treatment, it is an invitation to notice what does you good.

How to add brown when you lack a home base

- **Put it in food**
  A wooden table, a ceramic bowl, lunch without a phone. A meal should have its place and you are not the last item on the list.
- **Put it on**
  A brown jumper, coat or scarf in a natural material. Something that surrounds you comfortably.
- **Put it in your hand**
  A wooden pendant, a smooth pebble or a mug that is nice to hold.
- **Take it with you**
  A chestnut in your pocket, a leather cord on your wrist or a handful of nuts for the road.
- **Paint it**
  Wide areas with a spatula or brush. Your hands are busy with something that has resistance, a beginning and an end.
- **Take it outside**
  Bark, cones, branches, dry leaves and soil. Count how many shades of brown you find.

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When certainty begins to bind

Some modern interpretations regard too much clinging to certainties as a sign of imbalance of the root chakra. For your own reflection you can use the question whether your habits protect you or no longer let you take a step. **You do not need more brown.** You need to invite other colours.

- **Add orange**
  The theme of pleasure and sensuality. Warmth that gets you moving.
- **Add yellow**
  The theme of your own choice. Something you chose today.
- **Add green**
  An image of growth. A plant, a walk, fresh air.
- **Add light blue**
  A sense of space, if you find it in it. An open window.

This is inspiration from tradition, not treatment. Try gently and notice how you actually feel afterwards.

Picture it with an example

After a period of change you suddenly enjoy something familiar, tangible and simple. A brown jumper, wood or ceramics. **You do not have to turn it into a message from the subconscious.** Try to notice what exactly attracts you. The shade, the material, a memory, or comfort?

Next to brown other colours can feel warm. Green brings it to life, cream brightens it and blue cools it. **These are possibilities for personal reading**, not effects prescribed by a colour combination.

How to use this map

It is a way to sort out the themes you are living through. Do you add brown because you lack firm ground, or put it aside because being settled has slightly stiffened for you? **You choose the meaning.** An added colour does not diagnose your state.

Brown has no place in the classical seven-colour map, not even an eighth.

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Free painting – intuition

When we paint freely, without a goal and without trying to make a pretty picture, we often reach for brown when we want **something solid**, or on the contrary **something that does not feel like moving**. But we do not always know why. Sometimes we know exactly, sometimes not at all. Both are fine.

What may hide behind a brown stroke

The same brown area on paper can mean **something completely different each time**, depending on what is going on in us. That is why it makes no sense to read a picture like a test with a single right answer.

Support.

Wide earthy areas, often at the bottom beneath the other colours. A wish to have something firm underneath.

Warmth and home.

Caramel and honey tones, round shapes, a roof or a table. A colour with a specific place.

The body.

Chocolate and chestnut areas, a thick trace, a stroke with the whole palm. Sensuality without apology.

Tiredness.

Dull grey-brown areas without light. Something that is certain but tiring.

Stiffness.

Equally brown areas side by side, with no transparency. A feeling that nothing has changed for a long time.

Memory.

Wood, clay, grandma's furniture. A colour that carries scent and touch.

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Brown in a picture. Can it express what is happening inside?

Yes, it **can**, but it **does not have to**. When painting you sometimes reach for a colour before you can name what you feel. Brown can then give shape to warmth, heaviness, physicality, safety and also to something unpleasantly stiff. Equally it can simply be **the colour you had to hand**. It gains meaning only in connection with **your experience**.

A brown picture does not itself say that you need certainty or that you have got stuck in life. Art therapy works with the whole picture and how it came to be. With the situation, memories, the movement of the hand and the feelings during painting. A predominance of brown alone **is not enough for a verdict**.

I want it on the canvas, but I don't dare put it on myself

A picture and a dress ask two completely different things of you. You meet a woman dressed all in brown and it may occur to you that she is older, more serious or more settled. But what do you judge by? Perhaps you formed the impression from a heavy coat and a cut you link with another generation. **You did not read age from the colour.**

The same woman can look completely different in a chocolate dress, a well-cut jacket or a caramel jumper. The brown stayed, its company changed. If you like wearing it but do not want to seem settled, try one change. Add a lighter element near the face, try a lighter material or adorn the outfit with what matches your taste.

You do not have to dress young. The point is that you recognise yourself in your clothes and do not wear out of habit a look that no longer fits. Brown can stay. **Being settled is not a mandatory part of the package.**

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When brown takes over the space

First, let your hand work. **You do not have to paint a tree.** Brown can be a wide area, a translucent layer, a thick trace or a small spot among other colours. The interpretation can wait.

Three things worth noticing

● QUANTITY

Support, or a heavy blanket?

A large brown area can pleasantly surround you. At other times you start to want to uncover something of it. A small earthy stroke can tie a picture together. Too similar brown areas may blend, unless blending is just what you want. When you stop, notice whether you want to stay in it, or need to open a space.

● SATURATION

Chocolate, or mud?

Chocolate, caramel and grey-brown evoke completely different impressions. If brown seems dull to you, put blue, pink or yellow next to it and compare the impression. If it is too hot and rusty, try a cooler blue or grey companion. Perhaps it is not the colour that bothers you, but the form it has had so far.

● THICKNESS

Sometimes the hands need to work

Thick brown can be spread with a spatula, layered, or drawn into. A thin layer lets the ground show through. Sometimes the resistance of the material is just what feels good and you need not look for the right word. For a while it is enough that the hands are doing something and the head does not interfere so much.

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What to take from the picture

It does not matter what a brown stroke looks like. What matters is what you feel while making it and what is going on in your life at that moment. **Two identical pictures can have a completely different meaning**. One arose in a feeling of safety, the other after a long day when you were just holding on. That is why you will not find a dictionary here, but **questions**.

A picture can speak even after time

Perhaps a brown picture will remind you of a period when you were looking for a home. Or of a moment when you finally allowed yourself to rest. At other times you will find no such story in it. Meaning arises in connection with your life, not from a table of brown shades.

Answers often do not come right away

Sometimes you look at what you have painted and it tells you nothing. In a week, a month or a year, though, it may suddenly dawn on you. That is fine. **The painting will wait until you are ready to understand it.**

If very strong or painful feelings appear while painting, do not stay alone with them. Talk about them with someone close or with a therapist. This page does not replace professional care.

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Associations and stories

Our associations

Associations are the connections that form between us and a colour. We are not born with a ready-made list "brown = this", and yet they tend to be surprisingly similar. They are usually made of three layers: **the body**, **culture** and **what we ourselves have lived through**.

From the body

Brown is the colour of **soil, bark, bread and coffee**. It is the colour of things you can pick up, taste or lean on. That is why we perceive it as **tangible**. At the same time it can recall mud or something spoiled, and the impression changes quickly accordingly.

From culture

In Europe brown was long linked with **simplicity, labour and poverty**. The brown habit of monks, peasant linen, wooden furniture. Today it is also the colour of craft, coffee, chocolate and nature. We will look at this in more detail in the chapter on cultures.

From what you have lived

Your grandparents' home, brown furniture, a jumper that kept you warm, or a wardrobe from which nothing could be thrown out. These memories decide the most. **Two women can look at the same brown** and one smells cake and safety, the other hears the sentence "we don't do that here".

When you know where your associations come from, it is easier to tell what is really "brown" and what is your story about it. You can ask yourself now. **What does brown connect with first for me, and where do I know it from?**

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Stories

Brown has several stories worth untangling. They show where the colour ends and where what people make of it begins.

Mummy brown

Mummy brown was a pigment from ground bodies of Egyptian or Guanche mummies, mixed with white pitch and myrrh. It was valued for its transparency and its shade lies between burnt and raw umber. The first documented use dates from **1712**, when a Paris colour shop called "À la momie" sold mummy powder. In the mid-nineteenth century, in 1849, it was written that it was "in fashion".

The English painter Edward Burne-Jones is said to have buried his only tube in the garden in **1881** when he found out what it was made of. Production traditionally ended in the early twentieth century and by the middle of the century dealers had stopped offering it. Brown may seem ordinary, but its history was anything but.

Sienna and umber

The name sienna comes from the Italian "terra di Siena", earth from Siena, the Tuscan city where the pigment was made in the Renaissance. In English the colour name is documented from **1760** and burnt sienna from **1853**. Sienna and umber are both natural earths with iron and manganese oxides, which is why umber is darker.

With umber, researchers dispute the origin of the name. According to some it is linked with the Italian region of Umbria, according to others with the Latin word umbra, that is, shadow. The main source of the pigment today is Cyprus. Pigments of this family are found already in the caves of Altamira and Lascaux. Brown really is a colour that comes from the earth.

Sepia, brown ink from a cephalopod

Brown sepia paint was made from the ink sac of the cuttlefish. The word sepia is the Latinised form of the Greek word for cuttlefish. Sepia ink was used for writing as early as Greco-Roman times and artists drew with it until the nineteenth century.

In the last quarter of the eighteenth century a Dresden professor, Jakob Seydelmann, developed a process to make a concentrated form for watercolour and oil. Brown was thus not only a colour of the earth. More than once it also came from the sea.

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Emotions and feelings

The same brown can evoke **home** in one of us and **heaviness** in another, sometimes even both in one day. There is no single fixed effect. It depends on our body, experience, culture and situation.

Emotions

Quick and strong reactions that can appear even before you realise them.

Safety

A feeling that you **can lean back** and need not keep watch over your surroundings all the time.

And why?

Brown is the colour of soil, wood and bread, that is, of things that hold. After a period of change you may enjoy something familiar, tangible and simple. A surrounding where you do not have to be ready to react all the time.

Ask yourself

"What gives me firm ground under my feet today?"

Comfort

A feeling of **a soft jumper**, a warm drink and a chair you do not want to leave.

And why?

Comfort is a real need, not a sin. Brown materials, wool, wood and ceramics offer it directly. Just ask whether comfort serves you, or already holds you in place.

And what if I asked you now?

"What does my body good today?"

Sensuality

A craving for chocolate, satin and **a depth of touch** that does not need to shout.

And why?

Chocolate satin, caramel skin and chestnut hair carry warmth without a big announcement. Sensuality need not arrive in a red sports car. Sometimes it comes quietly and is certainly not boring.

And try answering now

"Where in my body do I feel at home?"

Aversion

A feeling that you **must not like** the colour, or that it simply reminds you of something you don't want on your shoe.

And why?

Brown does not recall only coffee and wood. It can also recall mud, dirt or something spoiled. You need not look behind the aversion for a rejection of roots. Sometimes it is just the picture the colour brings.

And now one question for you

"What actually bothers me, the colour, or what it reminds me of?"

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Feelings and experience

Deeper and slower states that settle in us. You often recognise them only after a while.

Home base

A feeling that you **belong somewhere**, even when a lot is changing around you.

And why?

A home base need not be large. It is an ordinary table, regular meals, a safe home or a person in front of whom you do not have to perform. Brown can remind you of what supports you even when nobody admires it.

Ask yourself

"What really supports and nourishes me in everyday life?"

Stiffness

A feeling that **nothing has changed here for a long time**, and it all somehow holds comfortably.

And why?

Brown can say "it is good here", but sometimes you hear in it "nothing has changed here for a long time". Old furniture, little light or a surrounding where new ideas were hardly welcome add to this. What one woman lives as certainty, another lives as immobility.

And what if I asked you now?

"Am I well in this constancy, or do I already need to set something moving?"

A worry that just keeps returning

Thoughts that **go round and round** and move nowhere.

And why?

In the five-element tradition worry and rumination belong, among other things, to earth. An activity with a concrete material can help. Repotting a plant, kneading dough or spreading paint. The hands attend to something with shape and resistance and the head rests for a moment.

And try answering now

"What could pull me out of my head into my hands right now?"

Homesickness

A scent, a fabric or wood and **suddenly you are somewhere else**.

And why?

Colours attach to specific places. Brown can bring back grandma's kitchen or a room where you did not feel at home. Longing or relief shows everything you carry with the colour.

And now one question for you

"What would I give my younger self today?"

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My brown is not the same as your brown

The colour itself **experiences nothing**. We experience it. When we first see a colour together with something strong (a smell, a face, a situation, a word), the **experience** sticks to it. The colour then becomes a **shortcut**. That is why **your own reaction** is the most important.

- **Wooden table**
  For one family dinners, for another an inheritance she did not want.
- **Brown jumper**
  For one comfort and warmth, for another the role of the good and inconspicuous one.
- **Chocolate**
  For one a reward, for another a memory of a ban.
- **Brown bathroom**
  For one the past, for another simply bad taste.
- **Chestnut hair**
  For one a frame for the face, for another a colour she did not want.

Why does it attract me right now?

Perhaps you needed nothing for a long time and suddenly something solid is missing. You need not look for a message in that. You change blonde to chestnut and your own face surprises you in the mirror. As if it had gained a warmer tone and the eyes stood out more. **You did not get new skin, you changed the colour surroundings of the face.** Honey blonde can look warm and ash brown cool, depending on the specific shades.

Why can't I stand it?

Perhaps you see in it old flats, school desks or a surrounding where nothing could be tried. Then perhaps you are not rejecting the colour. **You are rejecting the life you link with it.** Try imagining side by side brown plastic furniture, a glossy chestnut and a soft jumper. The same colour family, quite different company.

When to keep it and when to take some away

Keep it when you feel good beside it and do not have to talk yourself into a pleasant impression. Take away when the whole seems heavy, blurring or foreign. First try one change. Lighter textiles, fewer things, a bit of greenery. **Grandma's armchair can stay, the whole way of life need not stay with it.**

Ask yourself

“Which sentence about brown is loudest in me? Whose is it, actually?”

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Brown in cultures and traditions

Brown is a colour people long thought of as "ordinary". Soil, wood, bread. Behind its reputation, though, are **more stories about craft, faith and trade than about the colour itself**. Let us visit a few places and read them carefully.

This chapter therefore shows **two levels**. First, how brown is read in different **cultures**, and then how **traditional systems** look at it, using it as an image, not as instructions. What is verified history and what is later interpretation, I say in each part.

Brown in different cultures

Mali

In Mali a cloth called bogolan is made, sometimes called mud cloth. In the Bambara language the word joins earth or mud and cloth. Men weave narrow strips of cotton, women soak them in a bath of n'gallama tree leaves until they turn yellow. Then they paint patterns on them with a brush or a stick using fermented river mud. **The iron in the mud reacts with the dye** and the pattern stays dark even after washing.

From a craft where colour is truly born from the earth and human work. Around 1980 bogolan began to establish itself as a symbol of Malian identity.

Brown here is not just a shade. It is **a joining of place, material and meaning**.

Australia

Aboriginal Australians have used ochre for tens of thousands of years. According to an overview on Wikipedia, ochre painting has been widespread for more than forty thousand years. It serves for body decoration, ceremonies, painting in caves and on bark, protecting the skin and in healing. Ochre was traded across the continent along so-called songlines and over four hundred pits are known.

From a tradition where colour has its purpose and its owner. Ochre patterns are, according to descriptions, the cultural property of a specific clan and the shades have their own meanings.

A colour can be **the memory of the land**. It is not suited to being made a decoration without a story.

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Italy

In **1525** a reform of the Franciscans began in Italy, led by Matteo da Bascio. From it the Capuchin order arose. They wear a simple brown tunic with a large pointed hood, in Italian cappuccio. The name of the order comes from this hood.

From religious life, where the colour means simplicity. Coffee with a little milk began to be called cappuccino after the colour of the Capuchin habits. In Vienna a similar "Kapuziner" may have been served as early as the eighteenth century.

Brown here carries a vow of poverty. And today we drink it as morning coffee.

Mexico

In Mexico and the region people drank cocoa long before Europeans arrived. The Mokaya people in Chiapas drank bitter frothy cocoa drinks as early as around **1900 BCE**. For the Maya the oldest evidence dates to around 600 BCE and before 400 BCE cocoa beans were used as currency. The Aztecs collected them from conquered peoples as tribute.

From ceremonies and trade, where brown had the value of a coin. Cocoa reached Spain in the mid-sixteenth century and the first documented official shipment to Europe is from 1585.

Brown here is not just a taste. It is **a colour of value** that people sent to one another.

Brown in traditional systems

Every tradition looks at brown **a little differently**, but all take it seriously. It is an old symbolic language and an inspiration, not a healing manual.

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Traditional Chinese medicine

In the classical system of five elements earth is linked mainly with yellow. Brown comes close to it in extended interpretations through soil and earthy shades. **It has no organ circuit of its own.** In the traditional system earth includes the spleen, stomach, nourishment and also worry or rumination. The organ names denote broader traditional functional connections.

How it relates to brown. For our work with colour the interesting theme is what I take in, what I give out and whether I forget myself in the process. Earth in this picture is **what nourishes and holds you**.

And what if I asked you now?

"What really nourishes me, and what only takes from me?"

Everyone has enough. And you?

You eat on your own standing up. You put off rest because it is not finished yet. In the evening you no longer want to choose anything, not even what would please you. But you are in that household too. In earth symbolism you can stop at care that should include you, not just as another task of being a more perfect carer.

How to involve brown

If it is pleasant to you, give it a place where you truly receive something for yourself. On a wooden table clear a space to eat. Take your favourite ceramic bowl and sit down instead of finishing lunch on the way between two tasks. **The benefit comes from the whole moment.** The colour alone does not replace nutrition or care for health.

Traditional Chinese medicine uses the elements as an image. It is not a diagnosis and does not replace a doctor.

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Ayurveda

Ayurveda is an old Indian teaching about health. It describes a person by three types of "energy", the so-called doshas. Vata (air, restlessness), pitta (fire, intensity) and kapha (earth and water, heaviness). Colours are not assigned to the doshas uniformly in the classical texts, so here you read **modern interpretations**, not an old table.

How it relates to brown. Ayurveda works with qualities such as warmth and cold, lightness and heaviness, movement and stability. Brown on a soft blanket can recall warmth and rest, on heavy furniture in a dark room heaviness. **No rule arises** from this such as "vata needs brown and kapha must not have it".

Pitta

This describes a woman who is purposeful, quick and thorough, who flares up easily. A muted brown and beige can feel cooling and calming. A sharp rust and brick may pour oil on the fire.

- **Beige and linen**
  Calming and light, as a base.
- **Beware of rust**
  A hot and rich brown can be one more stimulus.

Vata

This describes a woman who is imaginative and quick, but restless and often cold. The traditional approach stresses regularity and calming changeability. Brown on a blanket and in natural materials can add warmth. **It is best to notice how you really feel in it.**

- **Caramel and honey**
  Warm and earthy, without chill.
- **Evening and sleep**
  Soft textiles and warm light.

Kapha

This describes a woman who is calm, steady and patient, but who easily grows heavy. When heaviness and immobility predominate, the tradition advises stimuli to activity. Dark brown areas can deepen the heaviness, so give them **a light and lively companion**.

- **Light wood and green**
  A fresh counterweight.
- **Add movement**
  Orange or yellow as an accent. A scarf, a tablecloth.

After a chaotic day a cosy corner can be a relief. After long days without movement and interest you may feel like opening a window, adding light and going out. A useful question is whether your surroundings offer you just what you lack now.

An online test will not reliably determine your dosha. If you are more interested, consult a qualified Ayurvedic practitioner. It is not treatment.

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A Jungian view

Carl Gustav Jung, the Swiss psychiatrist, understood colours as symbols that have two layers. A personal one (what we have experienced with the colour) and one shared by all people (images that repeat across ages and cultures).

Jung did not describe brown as a colour of its own. What I write next is my own reflection in the spirit of his thinking, not his statement.

How it relates to brown. Soil, clay and roots belong to the images of earth that in the shared human imagination are often linked with motherhood and fertility. You can take brown as the colour of **what carries and nourishes us**. When you think about it, ask where support comes to you from and whether you accept it.

What you can take from it. Jung did not want colours turned into a dictionary. **We always ask what it means for you.** The same brown can be a home for one woman and a cage for another. Jung's ideas about colours are a symbolic frame, not verified science.

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Feng shui

Feng shui is the Chinese art of arranging space so that it is good to live in. In some approaches earthy browns are linked with earth and stability. With wooden objects the material itself and the element of wood also enter the interpretation. Schools differ in the assignments, so take it as one possibility.

Brown is like tree bark

A little gives a space firmness, a whole trunk turns it into a cave. Being settled is not the number of brown things.

Simple tips

- **Start with a question**
  Do I feel settled here, or swamped? The difference is often in the light and in whether each thing has a reason to be here.
- **Give wood the main role**
  Wood can remain the main character. It does not have to play all the supporting roles at the same time.
- **Vary the surfaces**
  Wood, leather, linen and ceramics work together better than five equally smooth surfaces.
- **Add light**
  A lamp by the armchair, a window without heavy curtains. Lighter textiles brighten the whole.
- **Watch the undertones**
  Reddish wood, a yellow-brown floor and a cool grey-brown sofa can "clash energetically".
- **Try textiles first**
  Before you repaint a room, try a throw or a larger sample and look at it both in the morning and in the evening.

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What people say and what holds true

MYTH Brown is boring.

TRUTH Brown is the colour of earth, wood, coffee and leather. In a flat it adds warmth, in clothing calm. It is boring only when it is everywhere in the same way.

MYTH Brown belongs only to autumn.

TRUTH Milky shades, caramel or cappuccino work all year round. Spring brown is simply lighter.

MYTH Brown and black must not be combined.

TRUTH An older fashion rule claimed it, today it is taken more loosely. Watch the contrast and the material. Brown with black can be very elegant.

What brown goes well with

- **Cream and linen**
  A lighter, softer impression.
- **Green**
  An image of nature and growth.
- **Blue and turquoise**
  A cooler contrast to a warm base.
- **Pink**
  A softness that changes a settled impression.
- **Orange and rust**
  Warmth. Make sure the whole is not too dense.
- **Black and white**
  Black is depth with a risk of merging, white adds separation of the individual parts.

Elements

- **Earth**
  Brown is its natural stand-in. Make sure it does not outweigh.
- **Wood**
  Green and wood enliven it.
- **Fire**
  Warm light and orange warm it up.
- **Metal**
  White and light metal lighten it and set it apart.

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Feng shui room by room

Living room

What works. A brown sofa can be a pleasant base. Wood adds grain, a leather armchair another surface, a linen cushion lightness.

What to watch for. When the sofa, floor, curtains and cupboards are all similarly dark, the individual parts blend.

A simple tip. Try a lighter textile, a cream surface, a green plant or a blue detail.

Kitchen and dining room

What works. Wood, brown ceramics and earthy shades connect to bread, coffee and everyday dining.

What to watch for. A small kitchen full of dark cupboards. A cosy kitchen is pleasant, looking for an onion in colour-unified gloom less so.

A simple tip. Add worktop lighting and a lighter companion.

Bedroom

What works. Chocolate bedding, pleasant wood and soft light create a place you look forward to. Brown can be bodily, warm and sensual.

What to watch for. When the bed, wardrobe, throw, curtains and carpet are all brown, you may perceive heaviness instead of cosiness. More as an image of a feeling than a feng shui rule you may then experience it as a "break-up colour". Brown does not cause a break-up, it can only be part of a surrounding that recalls stagnation.

A simple tip. Swap a large dark throw for a cream or light sandy one and let daylight into the room. If the feeling of emptiness stays, that is information too. Perhaps the relationship needs attention now, not another cushion.

Children's room

What works. Brown wood can form a pleasant base. But leave room also for colours, pictures and the child's choice.

What to watch for. A forest room does not have to be only trunks. It also has leaves, light and perhaps a purple dinosaur, if it has just moved in with the child.

A simple tip. Leave room for other colours and for a change of taste.

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Study

What works. A wooden desk can be beautiful and practical, it adds a firm base.

What to watch for. A whole room that recalls a study you went into to knock and rather object to nothing.

A simple tip. A lighter main view, fewer things and a colour that pleases you.

Hallway and bathroom

What works. Brown tiles or wood can feel warm and lived-in.

What to watch for. In a room without a window, watch how much light remains. A dark floor, walls and furniture turn a cosy impression into a cave.

A simple tip. A lighter surface, suitable lighting and fewer visually heavy things.

And try answering now

“Why do I want brown at home? What should it bring me, cosiness, a firm home base, or a wish to move again here?”

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Colour frequency and phototherapy

With brown people talk about "earthy vibrations" and a "grounding frequency". It sounds as if it had its own number that could be read off. A brown fabric **reflects** light, a brown lamp **emits** light. Let us say what of this is **atmosphere** and what is already **treatment**.

And it is just here that it is good to leave aside **miraculous promises**. A brown wall or a brown filter is not in itself a therapeutic light method.

What frequency does brown have?

Brown cannot be assigned a single frequency of light. A brown impression usually arises with darker yellow, orange or red-orange shades in a certain surrounding. How light the areas around it are matters too. That is why the same sample can look brown on one background and more orange on another.

Physics helps us here to understand one practical thing. **You do not see a colour separately from its surroundings.**

Why is it different at home than in the shop?

A sample may look honey-like in the shop but suddenly grey-brown or rusty at home. The lighting, neighbouring colours and size of the area all change. Before a bigger change, therefore, look at the sample on site in the morning and in the evening. A small piece under a shop lamp has not yet said everything it has on its mind.

Warm light is not a brown therapeutic light

Soft warm lighting can nicely accompany wood and earthy textiles. For reading, cooking or work, however, you also need enough suitable light. A pleasant atmosphere and good visibility should complement each other. If in a cosy corner you puzzle out every second word, a brown throw will not make up for the lamp.

Where light is really studied

Phototherapy works with specific properties of light, dose and purpose. If you are considering it for a health problem, **discuss suitability and procedure with a doctor** or the relevant health professional. In our guide brown has a place mainly as a colour of surroundings, materials and personal experience.

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Astrotype and colours

Are you Libra, Sagittarius or Pisces? The astrotype is a much broader topic than just the sun sign. If you really want to go into **depth**, knowing only your date of birth is not enough. The exact place and time of birth are also important, because only from them are the ascendant, the position of the Moon, planets and other parts of the horoscope calculated. Here, though, we stay only at the edge of what relates to colours.

Astrology does not assign brown unambiguously. It is most often linked with Saturn and the earth signs, sometimes with Venus in an earthy form. Sources differ here, so take it as inspiration. Depending on how the earth element of your sign relates to brown, it may feel close to you, or distant. Find your sign (the dates are approximate and change by year) and read what brown may say to you.

The ascendant is the sign that was rising on the eastern horizon at the moment of your birth. According to astrological tradition it shows how you come across outwardly and how you enter the world, while the Sun sign describes more who you are inside. For each sign you will therefore find not only its character but also a short note on how the colour fits when it is your ascendant.

Aries (21 March – 19 April)

Your brown

rust · brown · honey

A brown that **lets you take root without ceasing to run**.

Aries is linked with Mars, fire and the start of spring. Brown is for it like the charcoal after a fire, **what remains when it burns down**. Rust and honey may suit you better than a muted grey-brown.

What Aries is like according to astrological tradition

Element fire · quality cardinal · ruler Mars

Aries opens the zodiac and you can tell that it is first. It is a **pioneer** who gets into things before thinking them through perfectly. It is direct, impatient and likes to compete. It gets angry quickly but forgives quickly too.

Its strength is the **courage** to begin. Weaker is perseverance in long, slow matters. It does best where something is happening and where it can act at once.

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What it can support in you

Brown can support moments when you need to stop and do not feel you are losing. It fits where you want to be quick but lack a fixed point.

With Aries the strength is often in the first step. Rust can add **perseverance** and take away some pointless haste.

Shadow restlessness with nowhere to take root

In the shadow, Aries runs from calm to the next goal. Brown then looks like boredom that one can flee.

Aries fears that if it stopped, everything would stiffen. So it keeps starting and never stays anywhere long enough for something to grow.

The colour can help you here too. It helps to **choose one place you will return to** and let it be.

Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add Mars red or orange.

red orange yellow

Red and orange give brown fire so that it is not heavy.

Aries as ascendant

When Aries is your ascendant, you come across as direct, lively and decisive. People may see you as someone who gets straight to the point, and the first impression tends to be brisk.

Brown gives you a calmer impression than your tempo suggests. Rust and caramel are the closest.

In everyday life

Take a wooden object in your hand and just hold it for a while.

*When you feel like running further, take **a brown mug and five minutes at a table**. You do not have to prove anything.*

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Taurus (20 April – 20 May)

Your brown

brown · caramel · beige

Brown as **wood, bread and a mug in the hand**.

Taurus is an earth sign linked with Venus, the senses and stability. Brown suits it naturally, as a **material**, not as an idea. Wood, leather, wool and ceramics may feel like home to you.

What Taurus is like according to astrological tradition

Element earth · quality fixed · ruler Venus

Taurus is an earthy, **patient** and sensual sign. It likes good food, pleasant materials, nature and security. It gets going slowly, but once it decides on something, it persists.

Its strength is **reliability** and the ability to enjoy the present moment. The weaker side tends to be stubbornness and finding it hard to let go of what is familiar.

What it can support in you

Brown can support the joy of touch, scent and good food. It fits where you want comfort with a touch of ceremony.

With Taurus it is often not only about colour but about surface. Caramel leather and linen beige feel completely different from a glossy synthetic.

Shadow settledness you do not want to get up from

In the shadow, Taurus surrounds itself with pleasant things so that it does not have to move. Comfort turns into a place that is hard to leave.

Taurus likes certainty and brown offers it in bulk. Then nothing happens, because it is too good here.

The colour can help you here too. It helps to **open a window and change one thing in the room**, for example move an armchair.

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Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add green and cream.

green · cream · yellow

Green and cream give brown freshness and air.

Taurus as ascendant

When Taurus is your ascendant, you come across as calm, stable and pleasant. You build trust slowly and people often feel firm ground in you.

Brown gives your calm look warmth. Caramel and honey suit more than dark.

In everyday life

Take in your hand something brown that you like and notice how it feels under your fingers.

A brown mug, a wooden table and good food. ***Treat yourself to them without apology.***

Gemini (21 May – 20 June)

Your brown

beige · grey-brown · honey

A brown that **gives you a notebook you can write in**.

Gemini is an air sign linked with Mercury, curiosity and speech. Brown suits it as a calmer counterweight. Paper, the leather of a notebook and coffee in a café where you can write and also watch people.

What Gemini is like according to astrological tradition

Element air · quality mutable · ruler Mercury

Gemini is **curious**, talkative and adaptable. It learns quickly, likes to tell stories and enjoys it when a lot is going on around it. It can see several sides of one thing.

Its strength is **lightness** and wit. The weaker side tends to be scatteredness and a tendency to start more things than can be finished.

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What it can support in you

Brown can support moments when you look for firmer ground for ideas. It fits a diary, a work desk and a bag.

With Gemini the strength is often in ideas and words. Beige and grey-brown can add **a little depth**.

Shadow living everywhere and nowhere

In the shadow, Gemini is at home everywhere and therefore nowhere. Brown is then just a backdrop that can be swapped at any time.

Gemini likes to change surroundings and brown may be too firm for it. It rejects it so as not to commit.

The colour can help you here too. It helps to **have one place that is yours**, even if you only return occasionally.

Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add Mercury yellow or light blue.

yellow | sky blue | white

Yellow and blue give brown clarity of thought and airiness.

Gemini as ascendant

When Gemini is your ascendant, you come across as lively, friendly and chatty. People may see you as curious and youthful, even if inside you are perhaps calmer.

Brown gives you a calmer and more self-assured impression. Beige and linen are the lightest.

In everyday life

Take a brown notebook and write down in it three things that interested you today.

*When it seems you are only briefly everywhere, give yourself **a moment at a wooden table** and finish one thought to the end.*

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Cancer (21 June – 22 July)

Your brown

caramel · beige · brown

Brown as **a home that holds you**.

Cancer is a water sign linked with the Moon, home and feeling. Brown may seem to it like a safe blanket. In muted shades you may like **a woollen blanket, wood and warm light**.

What Cancer is like according to astrological tradition

Element water · quality cardinal · ruler Moon

Cancer is **caring**, sensitive and strongly connected to home and family. It has a good memory for feelings and relationships. It enters the world cautiously, much like a crab with its shell.

Its strength is **empathy** and the ability to create safety. The weaker side tends to be changeable moods and a tendency to withdraw when it feels hurt.

What it can support in you

Brown can support moments when you want to make a home more pleasant or give someone something warm.

With Cancer the strength is often in empathy. Caramel can add **permission for care for yourself too**.

Shadow closing yourself in your own nest

In the shadow, Cancer pulls everyone inside and leaves the world outside. A brown home then turns into a fortress.

Cancers fear that if they opened the door, they would lose certainty. The home is then so safe that you do not want to leave it.

The colour can help you here too. It helps to **invite someone for coffee** and let them have a look.

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Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add the Moon's white and silver.

white · silver · cream

White and silver give brown light and openness.

Cancer as ascendant

When Cancer is your ascendant, you come across as gentle and careful. At first you keep your distance, but then warmth unfolds and people see in you someone who will look after them.

Brown gives you a sense of warmth and carefulness. Muted and warm shades suit.

In everyday life

In the evening take a brown mug in your hand and sit for a while without tasks.

*When you are tired of watching over the home, take **a brown towel or cup** and remind yourself that care applies to you too.*

Leo (23 July – 22 August)

Your brown

chocolate · caramel · gold

A brown that **lets you be warm and dignified at once**.

Leo is a fire sign ruled by the Sun. Brown suits it in warm and deep forms. Chocolate skin, caramel and a golden patina as **a sunset over a field**.

What Leo is like according to astrological tradition

Element fire · quality fixed · ruler Sun

Leo is **generous**, proud and creative. It likes to give, likes to rejoice and needs others to see and appreciate it. It is loyal and has a big heart.

Its strength is **warmth** and the ability to inspire others. The weaker side tends to be sensitivity to criticism and a tendency to want to be the centre of attention.

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What it can support in you

Brown can support moments when you want to be yourself without shouting. It fits a leather coat, wooden jewellery and an autumn dinner.

With Leo the strength is often in creativity and generosity. Chocolate can add **calm dignity**.

Shadow home as a stage

In the shadow, Leo furnishes the home to make an impression. Brown becomes a set for guests.

Leo needs recognition and the home may be the place where it looks for it. When the guest leaves, emptiness arrives.

The colour can help you here too. It helps to **have one place at home that is not for anyone**, just for you.

Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add gold or deep blue.

gold · dark blue · cream

Gold and dark blue give brown maturity and shine.

Leo as ascendant

When Leo is your ascendant, you come across as self-assured, warm and striking. You enter a room in a way that people notice you even when you do not want them to.

Brown gives you warmth and dignity. Chocolate and caramel suit better than grey-brown.

In everyday life

Put on something brown today that you did not choose for others.

*When you feel you must shine, take **a brown thing that warms only you**.*

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Virgo (23 August – 22 September)

Your brown

beige · linen · brown

Brown as **clean linen and a wooden table**.

Virgo is an earth sign linked with Mercury, order and care for detail. Brown suits it in calm and natural forms. **Linen, paper and wood** without an excess of ornament.

What Virgo is like according to astrological tradition

Element earth · quality mutable · ruler Mercury

Virgo is **meticulous**, attentive and practical. It notices details that others overlook and likes to be useful. It tends to be modest and judges itself more strictly than others.

Its strength is **reliability** and the ability to improve things. The weaker side tends to be perfectionism, worries and a tendency to criticise itself.

What it can support in you

Brown can support moments when you want to tidy up both space and head. It fits a work desk, a pantry and a wardrobe.

With Virgo the strength is often in attention and order. Linen and beige can add **a little forgiveness**.

Shadow endless tidying instead of rest

In the shadow, Virgo turns the home into a project. Brown things are always imperfect in something and there is always something to repair.

Virgo likes order and brown is a colour through which patina shows. Then it fears it is not clean enough.

The colour can help you here too. It helps to **leave one thing deliberately dusty** and sit down beside it.

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Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add Mercury grey and green.

grey · green · white

Grey and green add order and calm.

Virgo as ascendant

When Virgo is your ascendant, you come across as neat, restrained and reliable. People see you as observant and sensible, sometimes even overly reserved.

Brown gives you a gentle and careful impression. Beige and linen suit better than dark.

In everyday life

Put a brown mug on your desk and do not correct anything about it.

*When you feel strict, try **leaving one thing imperfect** and looking at it in warm light.*

Libra (23 September – 22 October)

Your brown

pink-brown · beige · caramel

A brown that **suits you in gentleness and style**.

Libra is an air sign ruled by Venus. Brown suits it in soft and balanced tones. Pink-brown and beige as **a coffee cake on a good plate**.

What Libra is like according to astrological tradition

Element air · quality cardinal · ruler Venus

Libra longs for **harmony**, beauty and justice. It is diplomatic, sociable and has a feel for aesthetics. It lives best in relationships in which it does not feel alone.

Its strength is **tact** and the ability to see both sides. The weaker side tends to be hesitation and a tendency to avoid conflict even when it would help.

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What it can support in you

Brown can support moments when you want beauty and balance without shouting. It fits a flat, flowers and clothing.

With Libra the strength is often in taste and diplomacy. Brown can add **permission to stay with your own**.

Shadow a lovely home in which nothing is decided

In the shadow, Libra furnishes endlessly. Brown becomes the colour that can be changed tomorrow.

Libra wants everything to match. So it postpones decisions and the home stays unfinished.

The colour can help you here too. It helps to **choose one thing and leave it in place for ten days**.

Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add Venus green and white.

green · white · powder pink

Green and white add calm and reality.

Libra as ascendant

When Libra is your ascendant, you come across as elegant, pleasant and balanced. People like you for your tact, even if inside you take a long time to decide.

Brown gives you a pleasant and balanced impression. Pink-brown suits your manner best.

In everyday life

Try a brown scarf or a wooden bowl on the table and notice what you like and what merely does not bother you.

*When everything seems too sweet, take **one thing in a darker brown** that has its own voice.*

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Scorpio (23 October – 21 November)

Your brown

dark · chestnut · chocolate

A brown that **allows depth without drama**.

Scorpio is a water sign linked with Mars and Pluto, depth and transformation. Brown is for it soil, **where something can be hidden and something of it will grow**. Chestnut and dark chocolate may be closer to you than beige.

What Scorpio is like according to astrological tradition

Element water · quality fixed · ruler Mars, in the newer view also Pluto

Scorpio is **intense**, deep and loyal. It feels strongly, but does not always show it. It dislikes superficiality and likes to get to what is hidden.

Its strength is **determination** and the ability to transform. The weaker side tends to be distrust, jealousy and a need to keep things under control.

What it can support in you

Brown can support moments when you want to be close, but in your own way. It suits a private detail.

With Scorpio the strength is often in depth and loyalty. Chestnut can add **calm after the storm**.

Shadow buried things that are not talked about

In the shadow, Scorpio buries in itself everything that hurt. Brown then serves as the earth under which it lies.

After being hurt, Scorpios open up with difficulty. A colour that is so earthy and silent suits this perfectly. But even buried things rot one day.

The colour can also help you here. It helps you **take one thing out and put it in the light**.

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Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add black or dark wine.

black · wine · red

Black and wine give brown protection and mystery.

Scorpio as ascendant

When Scorpio is your ascendant, you come across as focused, mysterious and strong. People sense the intensity of your gaze and often feel that you know more than you say.

Brown gives you a calm depth behind a mysterious impression. Chestnut is the closest.

In everyday life

Try having brown just for yourself in something nobody sees.

*When you want to withdraw, put on **brown jewellery under your clothes** and let it be your secret.*

Sagittarius (22 November – 21 December)

Your brown

rust · honey · brown

Brown as **a dusty road and a view from a hill**.

Sagittarius is a fire sign linked with Jupiter, freedom and distances. Brown suits it as the colour of the road, **of boot leather and rucksack canvas**. Rust and honey as the colour of land you have not yet crossed.

What Sagittarius is like according to astrological tradition

Element fire · quality mutable · ruler Jupiter

Sagittarius is **optimistic**, open and free-spirited. It loves travel, new experiences and the search for meaning. It speaks honestly, sometimes a little too directly.

Its strength is **enthusiasm** and faith in a good outcome. The weaker side tends to be impatience with detail and a tendency to promise more than can be managed.

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What it can support in you

Brown can support moments when you want to set out but have somewhere to return to. It fits a journey, nature and a café.

With Sagittarius the strength is often in optimism and momentum. Brown can add **the awareness of where you set out from**.

Shadow living out of a suitcase so as not to have to stay

In the shadow, Sagittarius travels so as not to have to settle. Brown becomes the colour of a rucksack, not of a home.

Sagittarians love freedom and a home may seem a trap. Roots then look like a cage.

The colour can help you here too. It helps to **have one thing at home that waits for you**, for example a mug.

Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add Jupiter blue or gold.

blue gold green

Blue and gold give brown reach and momentum.

Sagittarius as ascendant

When Sagittarius is your ascendant, you come across as open, jovial and adventurous. People see you as someone with a wide outlook and an appetite for discovery.

Brown gives you a friendly and open impression. Rust and honey suit more than dark.

In everyday life

Take a brown scarf or mug on the road and put it in the same place after you return.

*When something feels tight, try **looking to see whether it is only closeness**.*

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Capricorn (22 December – 19 January)

Your brown

chocolate · grey-brown · brown

A brown that **lets you be firm and warm**.

Capricorn is an earth sign linked with Saturn, responsibility and perseverance. Brown suits it naturally, as the colour of wood and leather, **proven by long years**. Chocolate and grey-brown add a maturity that can warm.

What Capricorn is like according to astrological tradition

Element earth · quality cardinal · ruler Saturn

Capricorn is **responsible**, goal-oriented and disciplined. It likes to build and is not afraid of a long road. It has a dry sense of humour and shows it only to those it trusts.

Its strength is **perseverance** and the ability to see things through. The weaker side tends to be strictness with itself, reserve and a tendency to put joy off until later.

What it can support in you

Brown can support moments when you want to lay a firm foundation. It fits an office, a house and long-term plans.

With Capricorn the strength is often in order and perseverance. Chocolate can add **a willingness to rest**.

Shadow duty instead of home

In the shadow, Capricorn turns the home into a task. Brown becomes the colour of duty, not of comfort.

Capricorn fears that if it rested, it would achieve nothing. Then even the home is full of what should be done.

The colour can help you here too. It can help you **find one place where nothing gets improved**.

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Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add Saturn grey and black.

graphite · black · cream

Grey and black give brown weight and stability.

Capricorn as ascendant

When Capricorn is your ascendant, you come across as serious, mature and reserved. People may see you as older than you are, and only later discover how funny you are.

Brown gives you a trustworthy and calm impression. Chocolate works best.

In everyday life

Put a brown lining or button on serious clothing.

*When you are too strict, try to **look at a brown thing and not improve anything**.*

Aquarius (20 January – 18 February)

Your brown

grey-brown · beige · sky blue

Brown as **an unexpected idea** among colours.

Aquarius is an air sign linked with Saturn and Uranus, independence and ideas. Brown belongs to it as an inconspicuous choice that surprises. Grey-brown next to light blue looks like **the colour of a calm future**.

What Aquarius is like according to astrological tradition

Element air · quality fixed · ruler Saturn, in the newer view also Uranus

Aquarius is **independent**, original and idealistic. It is interested in ideas, humanity and the future. It wants to go its own way and does not like adapting to expectations.

Its strength is **perspective** and the ability to come up with new things. The weaker side tends to be distance from feelings and a tendency to withdraw when there is too much closeness.

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What it can support in you

Brown can support moments when you want something unusual, but with calm. It fits a poster, a logo and clothing.

With Aquarius the strength is often in originality and perspective. Brown can add **firm ground under ideas**.

Shadow home in the head instead of the body

In the shadow, Aquarius thinks about home instead of being in it. Brown becomes a concept, not an experience.

Aquarians like to keep a detached view and solid things seem to them not very original. The body then waits for a touch that does not come.

The colour can also help you here. It helps you **take something rough and natural in your hand** and just notice it for a while.

Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add a cool blue or silver.

sky blue · silver · white

Blue and silver give brown clarity and distance.

Aquarius as ascendant

When Aquarius is your ascendant, you come across as independent, a little unusual and friendly. People see you as an original personality who keeps their own space.

Brown gives you an unexpected and friendly impression. Grey-brown and beige are the closest.

In everyday life

Try putting one brown thing in your bag for a week and not explaining it.

*When everything seems too earthly to you, try to **tell yourself what you like about it**.*

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Pisces (19 February – 20 March)

Your brown

linen · beige · caramel

Brown as **a firm shore** for dreamy water.

Pisces is a water sign linked with Jupiter and Neptune, feeling and imagination. Brown can give it a firm shore. Linen and beige may remind you of **sand, wood and an old boat**.

What Pisces is like according to astrological tradition

Element water · quality mutable · ruler Jupiter, in the newer view also Neptune

Pisces is **empathic**, intuitive and dreamy. It picks up the moods around it and often has a rich imagination. It frequently has a bond with art, music and spirituality.

Its strength is **compassion** and creative fantasy. The weaker side tends to be merging with other people's feelings, escaping into dreams and difficulty setting boundaries.

What it can support in you

Brown can support moments when you need to anchor yourself. It fits a bedroom, a picture and a scent.

With Pisces the strength is often in empathy and imagination. Brown can add **a willingness to stand firm even in a current**.

Shadow dissolving in someone else's home

In the shadow, Pisces merges with the surroundings of others. Brown is then not theirs but only a reflection of someone else's home base.

Pisces are sensitive and easily take on someone else's atmosphere. The home becomes a place where one's own boundaries are lost.

The colour can also help you here. It helps you **have one thing at home that you chose yourself**.

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Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add brown with blue or green.

blue green cream

Blue and green give brown soil and water.

Pisces as ascendant

When Pisces is your ascendant, you come across as gentle, dreamy and adaptable. People like to project their wishes onto you and tend to be kind to you.

Brown gives you a soft and calm impression. Linen and beige are the closest.

In everyday life

In the evening light a candle, take a wooden thing and write three sentences about your day.

*When you feel like running away, take **a brown thing firmly in your hand** and return to the room.*

FOR A DEEPER LOOK

Seasons

Brown is the colour of autumn and early spring. Leaves, bark, ploughed land and wood in the fireplace. Winter adds dark chocolate tones, summer almost drowns it out with green. Ask yourself when you reach for it.

Time of day

In the morning coffee and bread belong with brown, in the evening lamplight on wood. Midday tends to be too sharp for earthy tones and they lose depth.

Years of life

Saturn orbits the Sun in roughly 29 years. Astrology speaks of its returns at about 29 and 58 and reads them as times when a person asks what is truly their own. Brown may feel close to you in those years as a reminder of roots, or on the contrary foreign, like a farewell to a role that only adapted. Both are natural. Research by Palmer and Schloss (2010) also reports that we like colours according to the things and experiences we link with them. Astrology does not rule that out, it merely offers another view.

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Colour for your website and business

Yes, mainly where you sell craft, food and care. Brown promises a home base and authenticity, but can easily feel heavy.

In business, brown is a colour that **invites trust**, but at the same time carries a label of old-fashionedness. It can look honest, homely, natural and also luxurious. That is why it is good to know what you are promising before you let it into your logo, website or advert.

By itself, though, it **does not attract customers** like a magnet. It can help create a **distinctive impression**, but what still decides is mainly **what you sell**, **to whom** and **how well** it all works together.

What we are telling the customer

Brown can say, for example

"It's honest." "You are at home here." "It's from nature." "You can rely on it."

- **Craft and tradition.** Wood, leather, ceramics. Tradition can be alive, it does not have to look dusty.
- **Food and drink.** Coffee, bread, chocolate and baking. It links directly to the product.
- **Nature.** Brown paper can look simple and natural, but does not guarantee an ecological origin.
- **Home base and ease.** Earthy shades accompany a feeling of comfort, privacy and contact with natural materials.
- **Luxury.** Deep chocolate and leather brown can look exclusive if well executed.

Depending on the shade it also feels different. Caramel and honey are **warm and friendly**, beige and linen **calm and clean**, chocolate and chestnut **deep and serious**.

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Simple tips

Towards a lighter companion

Brown with cream and white looks lighter. Keep large areas light.

Show the real material

The grain of wood, a detail of hands, the surface of the product. A real story is usually more interesting than an artificial patina on everything including the price list.

Shade by role

Chocolate for depth, caramel for friendliness, beige for calm.

Legibility

Dark brown lettering on a similarly dark background is hard to read. Use a light background.

Cultural context

In India and in the army khaki is linked with uniform, in Norway with a home breakfast. Before you go out into the world, find out what brown means at home and where you are heading.

Colour blindness

About 1 in 12 men has difficulty telling red from green, and brown often changes in their perception. Do not rely on shade alone, add shape or text.

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Professions where it is a Yes

The rule is simple. When you sell a home base, craft or taste, brown can help you.

Café, bakery and chocolate

Here brown can link directly to the product, coffee beans, bread crust, cocoa. Give it a lighter companion and let real photographs stand out. When the packaging, background, table and cake are all brown, a visitor may spend a while looking for what to order.

Wood, ceramics, leather and craft

Brown here naturally links to the material and honest work. Show a detail of hands and the surface. Tradition can be alive and need not look dusty.

Body care, massage and stays

Earthy shades accompany a feeling of comfort and privacy. Make sure, though, that friendliness does not vanish in a dark or constantly beige whole. A person should see who will receive them, what you offer and how to book.

Outdoor movement, camps and outdoor sport

Brown with olive and green links to forests, trails and soil. For a sports brand it will need a sharper companion so that it does not look slow.

Professions where it is a No

This is not a ban for whole fields. What decides is the interplay of colour, text, photographs and setting.

- **Playful children's projects.** Brown alone may lack the variety you want to offer.
- **Projects built on lightness and freshness.** A heavy earthy tone may raise different expectations.
- **Long texts and important information.** Dark brown lettering on a dark background is hard to read.
- **Photographs of skin, food and art.** A brown filter can distort the real colours.
- **Dark waiting rooms and corridors.** More dark surfaces can strengthen a gloomy impression.

Try a striking shade in waiting rooms and rest areas first in a smaller amount.

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Before you send it out into the world

Show the design to a woman who does not know your offer and ask "What would you expect from such a place or service?" **Is the offer visible, or mainly the brown?** Her answer may tell you more than the general rule that brown means honesty and earthiness.

A question for you

“What should your customer feel first when she looks at your website?”

Examples from the market

You know brown from couriers and handbags. Here are **a few examples** that show what it can do.

- **UPS (logistics)**
  The founder James Casey originally wanted yellow vehicles. His partner Charlie Soderstrom objected that yellow is hard to keep clean and that Pullman railway cars are brown. Hence "Pullman brown". In the years after 2000 the company used the slogan "What can Brown do for you?"

- **Louis Vuitton (fashion)**
  The brand was founded by Louis Vuitton in Paris in 1854. In 1888 came the Damier canvas and in 1896 the Monogram canvas, which the company protected with patents worldwide. Brown became its quiet signature.

What they have in common is that brown carries a simple message. **Honestly, warmly, for use.** And it is mostly not everywhere, only where it should stand out.

Colours in business are not law. Studies are mixed and a lot depends on context, on customers and on how consistent the brand is. Take it as an idea to test, not as a rule. The brand examples are publicly known and the facts about them come from public sources.

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Different colour combinations

Brown + red

How it feels

Brick and wine. Red gives brown a heart and brown gives red calm. Together they look like a brick house or dry wine in a wooden crate.

When it suits

When you want **warmth and strength**.

Specific shades



brown + red
warmly



chocolate + burgundy
deeply



beige + coral
earthily



caramel + scarlet
boldly



linen + brick
subduedly

In practice

A red scarf on a brown coat. A brick wall and a wooden table.

Watch out

Two warm colours easily make a heavy whole. Give one of them **more space**.

Brown + orange

How it feels

Autumn and oven. Orange warms brown up. Together they recall leaves, pumpkins and freshly baked bread.

When it suits

When you want **warmth and cosiness**.

Specific shades



brown + orange
warmly



chocolate + terracotta
richly



beige + apricot
softly



caramel + pumpkin
daringly



linen + rust
earthily

In practice

A rust cushion on a brown sofa. Pumpkin and chocolate in a kitchen.

Watch out

A whole that is too dense. Add **a light element**.

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Brown + yellow

How it feels

Honey and grain. Yellow lights brown up and brown gives yellow depth. Together they look like a field or mustard on bread.

When it suits

When you want **warm lightness**.

Specific shades


brown + yellow
sunnily


chocolate + ochre
golden


beige + butter
kindly


caramel + lemon
radiantly


linen + mustard
subduedly

In practice

A yellow tablecloth on a wooden table. A mustard jumper and brown boots.

Watch out

At similar saturation both are muted. Keep one **lighter**.

Brown + green

How it feels

Forest and bark. Green and brown are a natural pair. A tree, moss and soil, nobody blinks at that.

When it suits

When you want **a natural and calm impression**.

Specific shades


brown + green
naturally


chocolate + bottle green
woodland


beige + mint
freshly


caramel + emerald
earthily


linen + sage
quietly

In practice

A green plant in a brown pot. Wooden furniture and olive textiles.

Watch out

A sharp green next to a rich brown sounds loud. **Mute** the green.

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Brown + blue

How it feels

Soil and sky. Blue cools brown and brown warms blue. Together they look like jeans on wood.

When it suits

When you want **calm and stability**.

Specific shades



brown + blue
calmly



chocolate + dark blue
deeply



beige + sky
airily



caramel + cobalt
freshly



linen + denim
soberly

In practice

A blue jumper and brown boots. A light blue wall and wooden furniture.

Watch out

Both tend to be calm. Without light the whole can be **drowsy**.

Brown + indigo

How it feels

Depth and earth. Indigo gives brown seriousness and brown gives indigo warmth. Together they look like an old denim coat and a leather bag.

When it suits

When you want **depth and firmness**.

Specific shades



brown + indigo
at dusk



chocolate + ink
deeply



beige + twilight blue
firmly



caramel + ultramarine
dramatically



linen + grey-indigo
soberly

In practice

Indigo fabric on a brown sofa. A navy coat and brown gloves.

Watch out

Dark and dark blend. Add **a light colour**.

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Brown + violet

How it feels

Plum and wine. Purple gives brown dreaminess and brown gives purple ground. Together they recall ripe fruit and wood.

When it suits

When you want **sensuality and depth**.

Specific shades


brown + purple
earthily


chocolate + plum
sensually


beige + lavender
deeply


caramel + orchid
mysteriously


linen + grey-violet
dustily

In practice

A plum cushion on a brown armchair. Lavender flowers in a brown vase.

Watch out

A too veiled and stuffy whole. Add **a light colour**.

Brown + pink

How it feels

Wood and porcelain. Pink softens brown. Together they look like a peony on an old table.

When it suits

When you want **earthiness with softness**.

Specific shades


brown + pink
softly


chocolate + raspberry
deeply


beige + powder
powderily


caramel + fuchsia
autumnally


linen + old rose
naturally

In practice

An old-rose cushion on a brown armchair. Powder and chocolate in a bedroom.

Watch out

A too sweet whole. Add **wood or linen**.

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Brown + grey

How it feels

Stone and bark. Grey mutes brown and makes it urban. Together they look tasteful and sober.

When it suits

When you want **calm and elegance**.

Specific shades



brown + grey
soberly



chocolate + graphite
elegantly



beige + silver
lightly



caramel + slate
modernly



linen + dove
quietly

In practice

A grey coat and brown boots. A grey wall and a wooden table.

Watch out

A cold grey with a dark brown feels **gloomy**. Try a warmer material.

Brown + white

How it feels

A clean sheet. White brightens brown and gives it space. Together they look like coffee with milk.

When it suits

When you want **purity and lightness**.

Specific shades



brown + white
cleanly



chocolate + ivory
elegantly



beige + snow
freshly



caramel + milk
strikingly



linen + bone
gently

In practice

A white kitchen with a wooden worktop. A white shirt and a brown leather bag.

Watch out

Too much white can feel **clinical**. Add wood or linen.

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Brown + black

How it feels

Depth and contrast. Black makes brown a bold colour. Together they look serious, but with warmth.

When it suits

When you want **expression and depth**.

Specific shades


brown + black
dramatically


chocolate + charcoal
deeply


beige + anthracite
soberly


caramel + ink black
elegantly


linen + soot
discreetly

In practice

A black jacket and brown boots. A black kitchen unit and a wooden worktop.

Watch out

Two dark colours tend to be heavy. Add **white or cream**.

Brown + gold

How it feels

Caramel and shine. Gold highlights brown and gives it shine. Together they look festive, like chocolate in gold foil.

When it suits

When you want **celebration with warmth**.

Specific shades


brown + gold
festively


chocolate + antique gold
richly


beige + champagne
gently


caramel + rich gold
radiantly


linen + matte gold
subduedly

In practice

Gold jewellery on a brown jumper. A leather wallet with gold lettering.

Watch out

In excess gold drowns out ordinary comfort and the space recalls **a shop window**.

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A SIMPLE RULE

- When you want to **lighten** brown, add **white**, **cream**, **linen** or **light wood**.
- When you want to **bring it to life**, add **green**, **orange** or **yellow**.
- When you want to **soften** it, **pink**, **beige** or **caramel** will help.
- When you want to **deepen** it, add **black**, **gold** or **indigo**.

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